Bibek Debroy said, 'Critics are unaware of the situation on ground, the extent of financial inclusion that has been undertaken by the Modi government, and how the *revenue generated will help in enhancing public investment*.'[16]

Other Indian economists argued that this could root out corruption and make campaign finances more transparent. Yet others viewed demonetization, with its massive infusion of low cost funds into banks, as a quick way to invigorate India's banking sector, reeling under a massive burden of bad loans and non-performing assets (NPAs).

The thinking press was almost uniformly scathing in its comments on the move.

Calling it a 'Great Leap Backward', Amit Varma wrote: 'It doesn't achieve its intended purpose. And its unintended consequences could devastate the lives of the poor, and cripple our economy… *Corruption and black money are a consequence of big government*, of one set of individuals having discretionary powers over the actions of others. If Modi was serious about tackling black money, he'd bring about institutional changes that would take us towards the minimum government he had promised in his 2014 campaign. Instead, government keeps getting bigger, controlling more and more of our lives. *More government = more corruption*.'[17]

One of the most scorching indictments of demonetization was by influential publisher Steve Forbes: 'Not since India's short-lived forced-sterilization programme in the 1970s has the government engaged in something so immoral… *Money represents what people produce in the real world*. It is a claim on products and services… What India has done is commit *a massive theft of people's property without even the pretense of due process*.'[18]

Commenting on how the move had shaken the trust of people, Devangshu Datta commented, '*Trust in state and policy consistency must be high if you're going to keep your money dematerialised*. You must believe that the state will not suddenly act in arbitrary fashion to